

On March 13, 2010, our family attended the Old Goats luncheon in DeLand, Florida. For several years, Paw Paw gets together with a few of his ham radio friends for lunch and chatter. Depending on which member of the family is visiting St. Augustine (Nonna and Paw Paw stay in St. Augustine from January until just before Easter), the family tries to attend the event. On a few occasions, Tony has attended solo. Al's family usually tries to attend with Al being a ham radio operator himself.

This year, Aunt Millie attended (as she has in the past). Tony and I had the opportunity to sit with Aunt Millie during lunch and hear some fascinating stories of her childhood and her family memories. AnnaMarie was also able to sit and talk with Aunt Millie providing a treasure of insight into the past. Here is what we learned.

Teresa Masiello (never married)

two children: a son and Maria Carmela Masiello Cannito

Maria Carmela Masiello Cannito (called Carmela) had six children

Vito Pasquale (1922)

Carmela Melina (1925) (DeBellis)

Ottavio

Maria (1931) (Evangelista)

Teresa (Clinco)

Joseph

Maria Carmela Masiello Cannito was married to Vito Stefano Cannito.

Vito Stefano Cannito's mother was named Carmela.

Aunt Millie was born in January 8, 1925, but her birth certificate says Jan 12, 1925 because the midwife who delivered her did not get to

town for a few days to register her birth. As is the Italian tradition, the children are named after parents, grandparents, etc. Aunt Millie's name is Carmela Melina. Maria Carmela's mother was named Teresa. Vito Stefano's mother was also named Carmela. Aunt Millie had five aunts, all named Carmela. Carmela Melina is interpreted as small, infant, young Carmela. So that is how she got her name.

With reference to the marriage, immigration to the States, and memories of her grandmother, this is what we learned.

Teresa Masiello (Maria Carmela's mother) had two children out of wedlock. Her son was killed in WWI. (Maria Evangelista has an Italian medal from WWI that was issued to "Mothers and Widows who lost sons or husbands in the war." We believe it was given to Teresa Masiello because her son died in the war and was passed down to Maria Carmela then to Maria Evangelista.) Teresa raised two children on her own and had to provide for the family by working in the fields.

Maria Carmela married Vito Stefano and had 6 children. Four were born in Bari, Italy (Vito Pasquale, Carmela Melina, Ottavio, Maria); two in the States (Teresa and Joseph). Vito Stefan traveled back and forth from Italy to the States to earn money and provide for his family. Maria Masiello did not live with her mother, Teresa Masiello. Aunt Millie noted that Teresa (Aunt Tess) resembles Maria Carmela's mother Teresa.

The story has been told that when Vito Pasquale neared the age of 12, he began to be courted by the Italian army to fight Ethiopia by teaching him how to use guns, etc. Maria Carmela became very concerned about this and wrote to her husband Vito Stefano in the States telling him he must return to Italy and help take care of the family or she would bring the family to him in the States. She waited for a few months and did not receive a response from Vito Stefano.

True to her word, Maria Carmela took the family "into town" to process the paperwork for them to travel to the States. Realizing Ottavio was too ill to pass health inspections (Ottavio had been stricken with a high fever that caused harm to his body and mind. Any name for the diagnosis?) Ottavio was left in the care of a convent and was later told he passed away near age 16 due to this illness.

There were no doctors in town; only mid wives and when Ottavio was very young he had a fever for 3 days. They went by train to the city to see the doctor but when they got there, the doc said it was too late; the damage was already done. Aunt Millie explained it was like his blood boiling and like water, a small bubble of blood went to his brain and embedded in the part of the brain that affects speech. When Maria Carmela was getting ready to come to the US, everyone was examined and Maria Carmela was asked why she was holding the older child (apparently her daughter Maria (our mom) was fussing and wanted to be held). The inspection officials examined Ottavio. "They threw him a ball, he caught it; they threw him a stick, he caught it; but when told to run, he couldn't - his brain didn't work to tell him to run." (these are Aunt Millies words) The immigration officer said to Maria Carmela "I feel for you and if I could, I would. I'll do this for you - I'll turn my back but you won't reach the other side." Aunt Millie explained that they were checked aboard the ship as well as on the other side. As it turned out, the checking aboard the ship stopped a few people before them and Ottavio might have made it here. I'm not sure who cut Aunt Millie's hair to check for lice, but she said she cried for days because she was a young girl and she was bald.

The Cannito family came to the States in September 1933 on the ship The Rex. Maria Carmela took Vito Pasquale (approx age 11), Carmela Melina (age 8), and Maria (age 2) to the States as described above on the Rex. Maria Carmela had a friend write to Vito Stefano alerting him the family was on their way! Apparently Vito Stefan sent a telegraph

to the Rex questioning if the passengers on board were indeed his family. He received this response. "Si Rex".

The doctors aboard the Rex checked you out before you could get off the ship. Checked for lice, checked under fingernails, etc. Those that were not allowed to get off the ship were placed in a different area of the ship. The ship stopped at the statue of Liberty where they were given a 'sermon' about the United States being a free country. Then they got off at New York Harbor.

The following info in blue type are also some of Aunt Millie's words but you make the decision how to edit it or even if you want to keep it in the document: She was very emotional when she told us this.

She "resents illegals who can't speak English - she thinks her brother (Ottavio) could have had help here. She's sorry she told us the stories with bitterness because she 'hates them' (the illegals). Her mother suffered to get them here to the States- Maria Carmela did everything on her own! There was only one uncle (Nicol; her Vito Stefan's brother) ONLY ONE, who helped get them on the ship with suitcases. No one waved, no one saw us off. Maria Carmela only had a 2nd grade education yet she taught herself everything. Talk herself to speak English. She was told "if you can get a group of 5 together, they would come to the house to teach English. Maria Carmela did and there was lots of laughter in the house when the women were there learning English when they would say something wrong.

The family stayed with friends of Vito Stefano until proper house could be found.

As for personalities, Aunt Millie described her mother Maria Carmela as a very strong woman (as illustrated by her actions!) Aunt Millie described her grandmother Teresa Masiello as a very gentle and kind

woman who had a tough life. She would hide figs in her apron and offer them to the children as treats. Aunt Millie describes her other grandmother (Vito Stefano's mother named Carmela) as, well, not as generous and perhaps even a bit selfish in her actions thinking of herself first. Vito Stefano was one of six children from the town of San Saveria (?) Some of Vito Stefano's siblings names are: Franscesco, Nicol, Maria.

Aunt Millie also told us that Maria (her sister) seemed to have a passion for life and a daring personality that at times pushed the envelope and perhaps her parents' patience.

One last story Aunt Millie told us about her life. I asked Aunt Millie where she gets her discipline; not stubbornness, but discipline. She told us it was from seeing the strength of her mother and grandmother. For example, Aunt Millie met/knew her husband (Vito DeBellis) because their families knew each other. Vito DeBellis was called to fight in WWII. He gave a ring to Aunt Millie that one might consider as a promise ring. It was not an engagement ring, but Vito asked her to wait for him. Aunt Millie promised him she would wait, but told him if he found another woman, to go on with his life with the other woman. Although Aunt Millie had another suitor interested in her, she kept her promise, declined the other suitor's asking and waited for Vito DeBellis to return home from the war. They were married in 1946 and have six children. Promises are very important to keep.